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Lou Marini

Lou Marini has fashioned a creative and productive career through his musicality and versatility. He is a sought-after multi-instrumentalist/arranger and producer who is an integral member of ensembles ranging from the Saturday Night Live Band, to the Blues Brothers, to the Woody Herman Orchestra.

Lou was interviewed via Zoom on June 15, 2023 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and it's a privilege to talk with Lou Marini today, who is in Alabama with the James Taylor band, is that correct?

LM: Yeah. Gulf Shores, Alabama. It's really beautiful. You can't go swimming though, the red flag is up.

MR: And the red flag means?

LM: Rip currents, so they won't let you in the water.

MR: Yeah. I have to say that you and some of your bandmates present challenges to interviewers and here's why. I'm going to read this from, maybe a publicist wrote this: "Lou Marini is the seasoned soul and adept multi-instrumentalist, arranger, composer, educator and producer credited with inspiring the origins of a fan-following cult across multiple genres of music." So which thing am I going to ask you about?

LM: You know when I was in school at North Texas State I was a jazz snob. And then I was playing with Les Elgart's band and we had a gig up in — Les used to pick up, as did many bands — would pick up horn sections from North Texas. So we were playing with all kinds of — I mean I played the Lipizzaner Stallions, I played the Fort Worth Rodeo, I played the little military base gigs in the officers' club, I mean every possible gig you can imagine. Ice shows, Stevie Wonder, Gladys Knight & the Pips, you know we ran the gamut. We played for so many people. But I remember Flatt & Scruggs. Well the first thing that happened, we had to back up Homer & Jethro and after we rehearsed with them, and they were great, you know they were funny as hell. And after we rehearsed with them we started a little jam session and I don't remember which of them was the mandolin player, whether it was Homer or Jethro, but whichever one he was, he sat in with us and he played better than any of us. And then that night Flatt & Scruggs, the bluegrass guys, were the opening act. And I think we were playing for dancing or something. And Flatt & Scruggs, their first tune was a blistering uptempo [scats] bluegrass. And they were so relaxed and just played their asses off. And I think that was

history is so broad is that I like all kinds of music and the challenge of fitting in and trying to be yourself and play something pure and still honor the genre and not go outside of it, which I always thought was a great challenge. That was one of the things about the years in the jingles in New York. You know at ten o'clock in the morning you're playing flutes with like a Mozart style classical ensemble, and an hour later you're playing a New Orleans style funk tenor solo on a jingle you know. And I always loved that, and the challenge of that, and the pride and the cadre of musicians I was playing with in New York at that time. I mean you know we would be on sessions and the saxophones would be Mike Brecker and Ronnie Cuber and Dave Sanborn and myself. So you know you're on your toes. Are you really supposed to be here with these monsters? And so that is a reason why, and I still feel that way, to challenge yourself to try to honor whatever genre you're playing in.

MR: If you were in front of — you've probably done this — being in front of like career day at a college level, do students, do you run into jazz snobs and do they even know what questions to ask about a potential career in this business?

LM: Well yeah you do, but kids today seem very savvy because the internet allows them to not only listen to — you know in my day, Randy Brecker and I have talked about this, we were taking solos off records by playing them over and over again and learning the solo in real time. Now kids can do the slow-down, they can take a Cannonball Adderley solo and they have a choice of dozens, and then slow it down, learn the solo, learn what Cannonball does and then speed it up. I hear kids today that are so much more advanced than I was when I was their age. Kids 18, 17, who are already players. You know they can play.

MR: The same thing happened to me, and they come in as freshmen and I go hmmm, I'm going to have to up my game here.

LM: Well I feel that all the time. During the pandemic I had a burst of creativity and I recorded — I mean I wrote 13 new big band compositions and in February I recorded them with a big band that I've been rehearsing. And there are, in the saxophone section, the baritone player is Dave Rickenberg. He plays his ass off. He's in his 50s I suppose. There's two young saxophone players, an alto player named Andrew Gold and a tenor player named Sam Dillon, and they are monsters. And Lawrence Waldron is the lead alto player. He and I played on Saturday Night Live together and we've been playing together for years and years. He's a few years younger than me. And then the other tenor player is a guy named Matt Hong who went to North Texas and he's in his 40s, and he's a monster. So, and during the course of rehearsing with this band I had, you know, you could never get the same band twice in a row so you're always having to hire subs, and

just in the saxophone section we heard like a dozen young saxophone players all of whom just make you want to jump in the practice room and try to — yeah.

MR: I bet they were thrilled to be there too.

LM: Yeah. Well that's sort of a nice thing. You know we're playing for our peers basically and their approval, and a glance of approval from one of them after a solo means more than anything else you can get you know, so — I mean you know playing with James Taylor's band night to night, Larry Goldings, Michael Landau, Steve Gadd, Jimmy Johnson, Walt Fowler, you know, you pinch yourself you know. It's like some honor to be playing with them you know.

MR: Who writes the horn parts for these?

LM: Walt and I do. And you know that's been another thing because it's so naturally organic. I'll play something and Walt will go — because James will — at first there were no horn parts. So now we're up to in the 90s. And James will, at this point he'll say you know I think this tune is horn-worthy, and the rhythm section will start rehearsing it and Walt and I will — I'll play something, Walt will play something, we're like, "Let's remember that." And then we go into a hotel room or a room in the venue and sit down and listen to the track and start playing and sketching out stuff and the next thing you know we have a horn part. And without — totally without friction. That's been the one delight with James, it's so organic and natural. It just feels great you know.

MR: You must be cognizant of course of when he is singing and regarding the horn parts.

LM: Oh yeah. Yeah. But you know like at this point, between us, just between Walt and I, Jesus, we've played for everybody you know. And so we've had the opportunity to hear and play what good horn parts are about. So we already have a clear idea of where we should play and where we shouldn't. And you know James, and it's not always that you shouldn't play when the singer is singing, 'cause sometimes you do play when the singer is singing. It's not just filling in the holes, it's complementing and adding something. And James is very cool, he'll say, "I don't think that — maybe we should do something else there" and he'll have suggestions and they're always great. So yeah it's been — I play, I have juicy parts on bass flute, alto flute, flute, clarinet, and then the four saxophones. So it's not often that you know you have a bass flute in a pop band that's meaningful and fun to play. Yeah, the last tour we did this tune from the standards album, "It's Like Falling Off a Log," you know "It's Just Like Falling Off a Log," you know it's a tune that James knew from the 30's cartoon. And I played a clarinet solo on the record and so I was playing that clarinet solo and then I suggested that maybe Walt should play like a straight mute solo, to play it with me, and it's this charming thing. And we got applause for it every night. And 52 concerts I never screwed it up, so that made me feel

MR: As someone called it, an "agony stick."

LM: Well Frank Wess used to have a Christmas card that had him in a Santa Claus suit warming himself over a big fire with a giant smile on his face and in the fire were clarinets and bass clarinets.

MR: Do you have an issue with, first of all with all those horns, you must do a count when you're getting on the bus or wherever like okay I've got the twelve —

LM: No we have our crew — we have a crew guy that takes care of us and he makes sure. I make sure they're all packed up at the end of the gig and he makes sure they're all in the road cases and safe and sound.

MR: So if you're playing an outdoor gig like you mentioned I think the day before this session here, and you pick up a flute — you have four beats to pick up the flute and play it, what about the intonation because of the temperatures and all that?

LM: Well like the beginning of the tour we were in the Northwest. We started off in Washington and then Oregon and then Northern California. And the first five gigs were cold. And the rehearsal was cold. So you know I'm constantly picking up my horns and blowing through them in preparation for what the next tune is going to be. And then with the flute sometimes when it's really cold I just push it all the way in and hope that I can get up to pitch. Because like we play "Up on the Roof." And I've got six bars after I put down — I can warm up the alto flute at the beginning of the tune. But the regular flute, when I switch to it, you know I've got six bars where I'm blowing hot air through it as quick as I can to try to get up to pitch. And then sometimes you're sharp. And you're playing and there's nowhere to go to try to lip down —

MR: Yeah. The things you don't learn in college.

LM: True.

MR: So I'm going to pose this question to you and I should tell you I asked Tom Malone basically the same one. And probably, like most successful musicians, you're fairly modest. But can you tell me why your phone has always been ringing since basically when you started in the business? It's a given that you're a good player. But is there something else that young students should know about this path, where you arrived and how you got there?

LM: Well it helps not to be a prick. You know the more prickly your personality is the better you better be as a player to maintain a successful career. Because you know Gadd and I talk about this a lot. One thing about all these guys that I've spent my life playing with, and still play with, is they've never lost the magic of music, the feeling of delight and the exploration and trying to get better. Everybody that I know that is in my cohort is still striving. And so if you're on time, if you have a pleasant personality, and if you can play

yesterday. I've had experiences where, you know for me when I walk into a room and there's other musicians playing I'm gravitating toward a center of pitch and an agreed upon place where we're going to play, matching timbres, playing together. But there are some guys that you realize that they are by themselves. They are not listening to anybody else, and they don't bend. So if you're going to play with them you do the bending. But for instance like Alan Rubin, my colleague in the Blues Brothers Band and for so many sessions and stuff in New York, he played with you. Ronnie Cuber, our dearly departed, and another example of a prickly personality, but he played so great that you put up with it. But Ronnie could be a pain in the ass you know. But as far as like ensemble playing, when I was on Woody Herman's band playing with Ronnie and Sal Nistico and Frank Vicari, man that was a delight. Because the written information on the page was like 2/3 of the information. The other third was all the subtle nuance that they had arrived at from playing together and that when you joined you had to pay attention and learn those things. But you could feel them coming to you. And that indefinable thing about ensemble playing is one of the — I don't think Walt Fowler and I — we rarely discuss when to take a note off or how to attack a note. It's just we arrive there and we do it in an unspoken way. And that's the epitome of ensemble playing to me, and you know like playing lead alto or playing second alto or fourth tenor with good players in a well written saxophone part, that is so much fun. That's something that never gets old you know. I have a bunch of arrangements of my dad's for five saxophones. And they're written so that they can be played just by themselves or with a rhythm section and then you can solo and play. And they're just statements of the tune but when saxophone playing — when saxophone writing is really correct, and my dad's was killer, man it's just a delight to play that way. And then the more guys, the bigger the ensemble and the more together it is, Frank Wess told me that there were nights on the Basie band when everybody breathed together. He told me that they went to London one time and Basie said I don't know why I'm paying all this money to ship the parts to London, you guys never look at the book anyway.

MR: And there's this myth I think that the fourth tenor and the second alto parts are easier. And often times they're not because you get those, you fill in the harmonies and sometimes they're a challenge to play and also you're trying to fit in in the ensemble.

LM: Well that's one thing about good arrangers who actually take the time to, you know like sometimes the second tenor and the fourth tenor cross parts, just for voice leading, just so that you don't have to play two repeated notes. So all of the sudden the fourth tenor is above the second tenor instead of being below it. But good writers are conscious of that. One of the best at that to me is the guy — Phil Kelly — who I started playing with him in

part you are playing you feel like you're playing the melody. And that's — I try to do that in my parts. I don't always succeed but I think about it you know.

MR: Those — I think you said 13 new charts you wrote, can you describe where the initial idea, how it arrives in your head? Is there a — do you say it's time to write a funk chart, or gee I haven't written a jazz waltz in a while? How does it percolate?

LM: Well those things happen but you know like for instance one of the tunes on the album is called "Fat Man." And it was written probably in the mid-70s. And my friend, Joe Randazzo, who was my best friend, a great bass trombone player in New York, that was a heavy cat for the first half of his life. And then he went into like Weight Watchers — or got into a program and he was slim for the rest of his life. But that tune, "Fat Man" is a slow, sort of a bluesy kind of tune. And it's been sitting around. And then he passed away a couple of years ago and I discovered that he had written lyrics to it. Very insightful lyrics about being inside and looking out and his condition as a fat guy you know. And that inspired me to get off my ass and write an arrangement on that. And then David Taylor, the bass trombone player in the band, who is a virtuoso player, he does a lot of avant garde classical stuff. And I showed him the lyrics and he said, "I got an idea for this." And I was going to sing it but he played an abstract bass trombone solo and recited the lyrics over it. And that's the way the chart starts. And then you know I wanted to feature each section and I wanted to feature every guy in the band because Joe recommended like four or five guys who play in the band, younger guys that are in the band, including the two, the alto player, Andrew Gold, and the tenor player, Sam Dillon, were among the people he recommended, and some trombone players, a female trombone player named Sara Jacovino who played lead. And so I wrote a solo that went through the whole tune and then the piano plays the whole solo but the solo passes between — phrase to phrase between the whole band. So every guy in the band gets to tip their hat to Joe you know. And so that sort of came about as I was thinking about it. And one process that I do is I will write out musical ideas, I will write out in longhand ideas about ensembles or for instance this idea about a solo and then basically once I start writing I sort of eliminate about 2/3 of the things. And sometimes as you're writing other things occur to you and you find your way through the chart. But my method is that each — I want a very strong thematic thing so that I can take that theme and use it as the basis for variations and like there's a tune called "Amigion" which is Buddy Williams because on the set when I wrote the tune it was a tune that just came to me. I was playing, warming up, I was in the corner of Saturday Night Live and Buddy was on the other side of the room at the drumset. And it's a simple tune, it's sort of a bluesy, minor blues tune but the melody is [scats]. So I'm playing in the corner and suddenly I realized on the other side

"Amigion." So I used that as a canon. And it's fast you know. And after a shout chorus it goes into this canon where different sections of the band — and it works out great you know. So every song for me has its own harmonic ambiance that I don't want to go outside of, and it has themes in it that I can use as harmony parts, take segments of the melody and use those segments as back-up harmony so that instead of having a stock voicing the voicing is derived from the melody itself. And so it's a combination of notes that you ordinarily wouldn't do. These are the kind of things that I think about when I'm writing you know. So each chart has its own ambiance and it's own path through finding it. Sometimes I think, like I have a song that I wrote when my son was born, called "Little Louie." And I want it to be a standard big band chart you know, so that's one of the tunes that I'm going to write next. And then I have a tune called "Na Perche" which means why not in Italian. And I recorded it as a quintet with a guitar and just piano, bass, drums and guitar. And it's a real funky tune. And I finally figured out a way to, lying in bed a couple of weeks ago and thinking about the tune, I figured out a way that I can do — it's a slow tune and it has a funk way of playing the solo section, but I wanted to get away from that and suddenly it came to me that it goes into double-double time in the half-step above which I had been going to, and I was like ah yeah, if I do this little lick, which is in the chart before that double-double time, it sets up the double-double time and then it feels natural to go there you know. So that's the way I think.

MR: It's like a little bit of problem solving and do these answers, these solutions, ever come to you when you're not really working on it?

LM: One thing I've discovered is when I'm stuck if I go and listen to music that is the total opposite of what I'm working on that sometimes the answer will be — it'll seem like so obvious to me that I didn't think of it, and it's prompted by hearing something that has nothing to do with what I'm working on you know. But you're right, problem solving. Because sometimes if you just think there should be a dissonant ensemble right here based on this melodic pattern. Well to work that out the idea that comes to you and you write the melody out and then you have to supply those harmonies, what took five seconds to think of takes three hours to realize. And that's one thing about composing too, that I remember reading instead of getting frustrated I remember years ago reading one of Robert Craft's book about Stravinsky, and Stravinsky's work habits were superior. He got up, he had breakfast, then he worked for like two hours, had a nice lunch, he worked for three hours, his day was done. If at the end of the day he only composed four bars, he composed four bars. And that was cool. And that idea to me was sort of revelatory. And so one of the things that has happened to me in my ascendency is both in practicing and in composing, I've gotten so much more relaxed about and forbearing and

something right away. You know basically most of what I practice is stuff that I want to integrate into my playing. Well the process of getting something under your fingers is a long process. And then to have it emerge naturally into your vocabulary as an improviser, you know, a lot of times by the time you get something under your fingers you're bored with it. You practice it so much. But then it starts to come out in your playing, or fragments of it. I don't want to be a guy who learns a lick and then you get to the D minor 7, G 7 flat 5, and that lick you play every fucking time you get there. That's not improvising. That's something else. So my dad used to say you have to always be a baby. And it took me a long time to realize that when you're practicing if you can't play something you just have to slow it down until you can. A few years ago I was with Barbra Streisand on tour and Rick Hickman, the oboe player, told me that he had a colleague in the college he was teaching in in New Jersey who was a student of Julius Baker's and she once said, "You never make a mistake, how is that?" You know. And he said that when he practices anything new he practices it so slowly that he wouldn't make an error. And he increased the tempo so slowly that in the process of bringing it up to speed he never played it wrong. That's a very, very severe discipline. But it's worth emulating and thinking about because you know I tell students that you're sort of burning a neural pathway through your brain when you practice slowly and you repeat and you repeat. And a lot of times I'll say here's a lick that I'm working on. You look at your watch and you tell me when 30 seconds is up, and you count the number of repetitions that I do in 30 seconds. And so they hear that I've played it 20 times in 30 seconds. So I say, "All right, now if you practice this lick for 20 minutes, do you think you're going to have it under your fingers, at least better than when you started?" And you know a light bulb goes off. So you know it's like a mechanical process, that discipline process, to try to get to a point where it occurs spontaneously in an emotional, energetic — to me it's like an energy stream that — and the times that you're really playing well it's happening in some kind of automatic place — not automatic but — and if the thought occurs to you in that process that you sound good, you immediately crash out of that place and you're back into normal life. You know the improvising is a mysterious thing man.

MR: It is. Have you ever had an instance where you were leading a big band and they were playing your music and a soloist sounded like they were practicing what they were working on during their solo, and it seemed to be a disconnect to the piece itself?

LM: Yeah but you know most of the time it's rare to get instrumental players that, especially you know like usually the true improviser is a guitar player who has been playing along with records and he's a rock & roller, but he at least has the idea of a connection between singing in your head and playing what you hear. And yeah, sometimes kids learn — you

the effort to try to get somewhere with it you know. And then you hear kids — I heard a 16-year-old alto player — I wonder what he's doing now, it's been like eight or nine years ago, from Seattle area, who was in a really fine high school big band and this cat was already, he was a bad ass. And his mother came to me afterwards and she said, "You know his grades are slipping. He was a straight A student, he's starting to get Bs." And I said, "You know you're standing in front of a freight train at this point because your son is obviously totally in love with music and with jazz and with playing, and as far as I can see he's going to be a player. So if he gets a B I don't think it matters much because it seems to me like his path is clear" unless he decides — and you know there's a lot of guys, great players, who are doctors and lawyers, who the economic uncertainty of being a player is threatening to them and they bail. I remember when I met my Spanish wife and she asked me — who was a lifelong civil servant in Spain — asked me what you're doing next week and I say I don't know. That was daunting for her.

MR: Yeah, I love that — "What's your calendar like?" "Well I have to look." And I was wondering when you go, this tour you're on is fairly long, isn't it?

LM: Yeah.

MR: When you get a call, when you got the call to do it, did you have to look ahead into your calendar and see do I have to bail?

LM: Only like James takes priority, and we know that usually we're going to be playing in the beginning of the summer. And so I just sort of make sure that I have open space you know. But also, the business has changed so much now. You know for instance doing clinics. I did a bunch of them this year but they usually want you to commit so far in advance that it's difficult to commit to doing a clinic in March when you know that there's a likelihood that the Blues Brothers Band is liable to go to Japan. And so I try to either have a codicil that if I have to bail I'll get them somebody great — you know or else there's been times with James where I've had to take time off and send in a sub to cover for me in order to do something that I was committed to and I had signed a contract to do. But you know I used to be a recording musician who went on the road. And now I'm a road musician who occasionally records you know. And that's a natural progression you know they used to say like "Who's Lou Marini?" "Get me Lou Marini." "Get me a Lou Marini type." "Who's Lou Marini?" That was our path through the recording industry. And it makes sense because the business changes, new young guys come in, new young guys know their new young guys and that's who they hire. So we talk about this. And when I first got to New York I was already an experienced recording musician from my years in Dallas because there was a very busy studio scene there with a lot of great world-class players. And so I was prepared for the New York studio scene. But

with Miles were my colleagues. I overlapped them in the studios. And they were very welcoming and mentors really with advice. So through the 70s and the first half of the 80s we had a busy studio scene going. Then the computers and drum machines and synthesizers began to eke — cut into our business and things, and you went from having ten big companies that did most of the music to a thousand in-house one-man guys who hired the guy that he knew from the University of Alabama to play on his jingle. You know that's the way it fragmented and diminished at the same time. But those guys told us that in the 50s and 60s they were working nine, ten hours a day. They went from a 50-piece orchestra gig to a live radio show, played a live TV show at night. They were working like crazy. So we caught the tail end of a really fantastic era of recording that was — I feel privileged to have been a part of it.

MR: I'm just reading a book — I got to know Joe Wilder.

LM: Oh man, I loved him man.

MR: Oh, what a — I mean who couldn't love Joe Wilder? Musically and personality-wise. And he described exactly what you were just saying, that there was so much work, he was on staff and he played the television orchestras. And then, even back then, he talked about "and then the synthesizer came in" and so I guess some things never change.

LM: Yeah. Well you know it's not the first time that musicians got out of work. When talking movies took over, overnight basically, within a year or so or a couple of years, thousands and thousands of gigs from guys playing in movie theaters just disappeared. So you know I listened — like I was listening to the soundtrack last night of a series, a contemporary Swedish series that I'm watching on Netflix. And I realized that these computer sounds, they're just a part of our lives now you know. The atmospheric sounds in certain kinds of scenes in these series and movies that we go to have been subsumed by these sounds that can only be made by synthesizers. So I'm sure that there is going to be great music that's going to come out of these sounds but I don't think it's happened yet you know. And there's also something about, you know when I listen to these vocoder vocals, and the drum and especially the rhythm tracks, you know you could just as easily be listening to a washing machine. When you consider like Luis Conte is always playing, because he's such a master percussionist. He's always playing stuff for us from like African tribal music or Caribbean or Brazilian or — and you listen to this stuff and it's so much more complex. And the grooves are so intense that it makes the electronic stuff seem stupid. It seems infantile compared to what humans do on the nach. And I think about like what young people are listening to and it's like this mechanical stuff that has no soul to it, and if even the vocal is manipulated then even the vocal sound is not like hearing the richness of a singer like Ella Fitzgerald or Jack Jones or Red Prysock. I mean you know it's just

MR: Let me go back a bit — you said improvising is a mysterious art — a mysterious thing to do. When you play a solo, an improvised solo over a one or two chord vamp or a 12-bar blues, is what's going on in your head different than what you would play on "Giant Steps"? Or even "Body and Soul." In other words more chord changes — how do you negotiate the challenging chord changes of a song as opposed to a one chord vamp?

LM: Each of them presents their own challenges. The thing about playing over one chord is to not resort to hot licks, you know, modal patterns and stuff that you practiced. And I think so much of it just depends on the players you're playing with. If you're playing with creative players then somehow you're being presented with alternate pathways or suggestions or prompts or opportunities to go different places you know. And, or you could play something that they respond to and that leads you to another place. Playing a tune like "Body and Soul" to me, which is a tune I like to play you know, the challenge there is to find, you know like Eddie Daniels talked about, playing a sequence, a melodic sequence that goes through a set of chord changes so that the sequence isn't just root-minor third-fourth-sixth — now when you get to the major chord it's got to be root-major third-fifth. That, finding those pathways — but you know I don't think that the guys that we loved, I don't think they thought about chord changes in the same way. I think their ear — I mean I learned to play by ear and by playing along with records. So I didn't know what the hell I was doing as far as what chord changes and what the chord scale was. The theory, my dad used to always say that the theory comes after the guys who push us, and not just guys of course, women too who push us to another realization of harmony or whatever. Like Ravel had his shit together and then we're all still playing the chord changes that we like, like Ivan Lins you know. That's another thing that like I think about, man when you — like bossa nova harmonies, which everybody plotzes over, you listen to contemporary radio, you never hear a set of chord changes like that. You're only hearing triads now you know.

MR: I liked what you said about the theory coming after the creativity. Every once in a while I put on Cannonball's, one of his very first records with Miles was on it, and they played "Autumn Leaves." And the solo that Cannonball plays is utterly fascinating. And he's got all these sort of not-in-the-chord tones, but the way he fashions them I'm just in awe.

LM: You know you don't hear Cannonball so much but I was very lucky — we went to hear Cannonball in Dallas when I was in North Texas and it was when I was first writing. And I wrote a chart called "Codify" which is an abstract sort of 13-bar blues. And we had a great band and Cannonball, I remember that he — of course I don't remember anything melodically about what he played but I remember he played "Carnival" and he played like 13 choruses. And I had tears in my eyes at the end of it you know. And we went up

up. They came up to the school the following day. And so everybody was thrilled and Leon Breedon says, "This is a new chart by Lou Marini." And we played the chart and when we finished it I looked up and everybody in the band was looking at me. And at first I was like what's going on. And then I realized that Cannonball and Nat are standing right behind me over my shoulders, and Cannonball leans over to me and he says, "Lou, you a crazy motherfucker." And you know we became friends. And I ran into him like with Woody Herman's band, one time we were on a festival together and he comes into the dressing room in a panic, he says, "Lou, there's something wrong with my soprano." And I said, "Cannon, I'm not a repairman, I don't know what the hell to do with your soprano," I said, "but you can play mine." So he played my soprano on the gig you know. And various times over the years I got to hang with them and you know he's like Joe Wilder, there's nobody that didn't love him. He was just the fucking greatest man. And to hear him play, his rhythm, his pop on the time and his command of the horn and his sound, it was just — and Nat too. Nat was a killer player. Joe Wilder — I had gotten to know Joe in New York and I just revered him. And when I was a kid there were these "Music Minus One" records — before the Jamey Aebersold records — and one of them had Joe Wilder on it. And I just loved his playing. And so when I met him I told him about that and you know, so we became friends. And Don Jacoby, the great trumpet player that I met on the Stan Kenton jazz clinics, my roommate was Sanborn, Keith Jarrett was there, Peter Erskine was there, Randy, so many guys that ended up playing together over the years. So Jake came up to go to the Charles Colon Jazz Conference in New York and I took him to the conference. He was staying at my pad. And one of the first people who we ran into was Joe Wilder. And you know Don Jacoby was a famous trumpet player. He was a virtuoso player. So Joe knew who he was. And I said, "Joe, this is Don Jacoby, Jake this is Joe Wilder." And Jake says, and Jake is this little guy with the diamond and the moustache you know and burly. And Jake says, "Wait a minute, Joe Wilder the jazz trumpet player, beautiful soloist?" And Joe says, "Yeah." And Jake grabbed him like this and kissed him on the lips. And then, you know, they were laughing and they took off and they were hanging with all these other trumpet players. But yeah, Joe Wilder was a killer.

MR: Yeah. I got to play with him a few times in the educational settings and I felt so good about putting him in front of school kids. Like he was a role model in many ways. I'm going to test your memory a little bit. If you go to Wikipedia, your Wikipedia page, it has a very lengthy list of recordings you've played on, and I think it ends like ten years ago. But do you remember — I'm going to ask you a couple of things. Do you remember 1981 Peter Tosh, "Wanted Dread or Alive"?

LM: Yeah you know what's funny about that is my wife and I were on vacation in St. John's and we were going into Cruise Bay and we discovered this Surf Bar that played nothing but reggae and it was really a cool bar. And we were in there one night. We'd been in there a couple of times before, and this tune came on and the saxophone solo started, and I was singing along with the saxophone solo you know. And I thought why does this solo sound so familiar? I said, "Who is this?" And so we got the name — when we got back and got on the internet at the hotel and here comes Saturday Night Live and Peter Tosh and Mick Jagger and me playing the solo. It was me. I didn't realize — no wonder I knew the solo, I played it.

MR: Oh that's a good one. Okay.

LM: I was totally blank you know. It was like it sounds so familiar who is this you know.

MR: Was it done in a New York City recording —

LM: Studio. Yeah.

MR: Okay. And I'm curious like you get a call, who calls you normally for a one-off like that?

LM: Well it used to be that we had a musicians' answering service that the companies would call. But in the case of something like that I was probably called direct by either the writer or the producer who knew my playing and felt that I was appropriate for it. But there was a lot of times when you would be — you know there were certain companies where you were the second call guy. The first call guy was George Young. So if George couldn't do it then they called me next. And if I couldn't do it then they called Dave Tofani. Other companies Dave Tofani would be the first guy and I would be the third, so if the first two guys couldn't do it then I would get the call. So we were rotating around like that you know.

MR: Were they specific about, "Bring your tenor and your alto flute?"

LM: Yeah. Very specific yeah.

MR: Nice. What about, same year, Meat Loaf.

LM: Yeah. You know I remember that too. It's funny that you picked that one because Meat Loaf, that music, it's like Bruce Springsteen to me. Clarence Clemmons could play a great solo at the drop of a hat. That stuff for me, I have so much difficulty trying to play a solo over that kind of stuff. And I remember that session because at the end of the session the producer said, "Lou, don't pack up yet, I want you to play a solo on this one tune." And my heart sank you know. I'm thinking oh fuck. So — those driving — and then he said, "I hope you don't mind but I had an idea for this solo so I wrote one out." I was like, "No, no, I don't mind at all." So that was a written solo, not by me. I may have modified it in the playing of it but yeah, I remember that.

MR: Have you ever done a session that the producer or the engineer has you play like ten, like

LM: Oh they do that a lot. And sometimes with my guidance and sometimes not. Sometimes, but you know it used to be, especially when the Japanese were coming in over a lot in the late 70s and we were doing these sessions. I remember one time there was a tune, and it was a good Japanese keyboard player named Jun Fukamachi — complex stuff. And I played an alto solo and I must have done 30 takes. And they would be, "Lou, nice solo but can you play high notes when you play this place." And you know, like I'm thinking oh this is ridiculous you know. And then the 31st solo came and it had nothing to do with any of the previous solos and suddenly we had it. But George Young used to say, "Fight for your first solo." Because that's your most — a lot of times producers would have a preconceived idea about what they want a solo to be. So your initial response to what you're being fed and what you're listening to is usually a pure response and that's what George used to say, "Fight for your first solo" you know because that's you. And then the more you do it, like you can get far away from being you. But at the same time, sometimes, like I just mentioned sometimes after failing and feeling frustrated, suddenly something totally different comes in and the solo works. But you know like David Spinozza has a solo on "The Right Place The Right Time" a guitar solo which guitar players all over the world have learned to play. And he was coming out of a session and he saw Dr. John in the hallway and Mac said, "David, come in and play a solo on this tune" you know. So that was David's first take and Mac says, "Yeah, great." But David hates it because there's a place where he bends up and you know usually you bend down. And so it's always driven him crazy that guitar players all over the world have learned his solo.

MR: Okay I've got one more, name this session: [scats Paul Simon's "Late in the Evening"]

LM: Well you know I forgot that I was on that.

MR: You can't forget that you were on that.

LM: Well you know I remember, I had heard that tune so much and of course I knew it but you know in those days we were going from session to session and a guy came up for me to sign you know and I was like, "I'm sorry man, I played on Paul Simon but" and he says, "No, Lou, there's your name there." And it was like holy shit. It's funny how some things you clearly remember and other things which you think should be a signal memory — a few years ago a guy called me up and asked me to do an interview about Jaco Pastorius. So I said well I was not a close friend of Jaco's, I was a friend of his and I played in the big band and he used to sit in with Dr. John so, you know, and I had some singular events happen with Jaco, not all of them pleasant, not for me just seeing him in distress. I won't go into those. But I said, "Well what's it about?" He says, "Well it's that famous concert at Lincoln Center." And I said, "Yeah but what's that got to do with me?"

And he sent me some examples. I didn't know that it was recorded. And it was with Mintzer and Randy were the soloists and that guy Othello Molineaux was playing steel drums and Jaco and I don't remember who else was in the band. But when he sent it to me I could clearly hear myself in the horn section so, but man, I don't have a shred of memory about this. And you would think that like Bergeron and Soloff were on it, Alex Foster was the other saxophone player. Nothing.

MR: It's very interesting because I suppose it's — I'm not sure this is a good analogy but a fellow who sells insurance you might ask him about — oh you remember that day you came in and this thing happened in the office? And you go no, I can't remember that. I mean your daily work is —

LM: Well you know that was one thing about like the Ken Burns documentary. It was absolutely devoid of humor. And when I think of my life as a musician and you know I am a jazz musician but I've played so many different things that I don't know if everybody considers me a jazz musician but I've certainly, you know like you can't remember the music with Thad and Mel that night when Elvin came into the dressing room and said he wanted to sit in and Mel said no. And Thad is standing between him and the two of them start arguing and Elvin can't believe that Mel won't let him sit in and they get hotter and hotter and Thad is looking at him, it looked like a tennis match. And finally Elvin says, "Why won't you let me sit in?" And Mel says, "Because the last time you sat in you cracked my favorite cymbal, you're not sitting in." You know? You remember that. You remember the funny stuff that happened. And you know one thing I think about with musicians is we are laughing all the time. We are cracking — when I think about my life as a musician you know I think of the delight that I've had in knowing all these maniacs. And I think that one thing that happens is that when you spend so much time by yourself practicing there's — you sharpen your personality. I think that something happens that you become more singular. And that in your own, whatever your particular manner is you know. So you get these personalities that are so unique. I don't know, maybe I'm dreaming or delusional but I really think that you know.

MR: It sounds great to me, you've got me smiling. And I know what you're talking about, the interaction between musicians is something special. I'll wrap up here, because this has just been marvelous — with a couple of things — I may be the only person who saw you when I saw you walk the counter with Aretha Franklin that I was reminded that apparently John Coltrane also walked a bar.

LM: Really?

MR: Yeah.

LM: Wow. Well you know it's — I think Coltrane is like a — like I understand why there's a

MR: Orrin Keepnews?

LM: He used to do a lot of jazz, a big guy, had a beard, I worked for him a bunch of times. His name is escaping me now, but he told me he saw Trane one night with the band with Pharaoh Sanders and towards the end of Trane's life. And he said at one point Trane stopped playing and was beating on his chest in the music you know. Those glimpses that we have of — I mentioned earlier something about when you're sometimes when you're really playing and you're in a different place if your ego comes in you crash to earth. But I remember talking to Dizzy about that. And Dizzy said it's only happened to him a few times in his life. So you think somebody as great as Dizzy Gillespie saying that and I think that one thing about Coltrane was somehow he was in that place all the time you know, and that quartet was in that place. I was listening to that record that came out this year of alternate takes, or of unreleased. And they're just titled "Original #1" "Original #2." And you hear how free that band was and how they — you can only play that way when there's ultimate trust between the players. When nobody is bullshitting in any way. When it's just letting go you know.

MR: Is there something about the times and the state of society that you think might make what you're describing very hard to ever reproduce? And the reason I ask that is I spoke to Rashied Ali once and was trying to get at the attitude of the musicians when he played in late Coltrane's life. And he just kept saying, "Listen, the times were different. The bebop people had their time, this was our time." So I'm not asking this question very well but do you think that the time and space that John Coltrane was doing that in contributed to what he produced?

LM: Well I'm sure it did and especially, you know I think about this because I was very lucky to get to play a lot with Bob Cranshaw for instance and with Frank Wess and with Joe, and those musicians, Clark Terry, those guys, they treated everybody with such dignity and respect. And you know that they weren't treated with dignity and respect, but they were so elegant and so — they were big people, big humans. A couple of days ago we were in Jackson, Mississippi and Dorian Hall, this singer, who is a black cat on James's band and I were in the museum together and there was a video presentation, it was a white artist, I don't remember his name, but there was a screen with four panels. And there was a violinist, a white violinist, a white cellist, a white bassist, female bassist, and a black cat, bearded, two gold teeth, the kind of hat that the reggae guys wear, and he was singing what was a traditional song called "The Slaves' Lament." And the arrangement was beautiful man, a beautiful arrangement for strings. So the contrast of these white musicians playing and him singing — and you know at the same time that it was beautiful I had this feeling like we are so fucked up and you know it's like — is it ever

going to change. Like sometimes I think the original sin is so great that you know what I mean? I'm an optimistic person but there are times when it's like wow.

MR: Yeah. We can't outlive that or how is it solvable? That legacy.

LM: Yeah. Well, like Claude Gordon used to say, "Straight ahead and strive for tone."

MR: Okay. Do you get people, are you tired of people asking you about Steve Martin and King Tut?

LM: No, no. Because you know that was such a crazy day. The guys were all treating me so weird, every time I walked in the dressing room they were tittering and I felt like I was interrupting something. They had bought a stink bomb which they were going to put in the sarcophagus and then they thought they'd all get fired. And then the make-up, they had to apply at like 6:30, they called me into make-up, and it was horrible. It was all my arms and shoulders and my chest and all over my face. It felt so constricting and so weird. And then they told me that I'd have to wear it the whole night because there was so much stuff to do that they weren't going to be able to take it off and re-apply it between the dress rehearsal and the show. So then I had to get touched up before the show itself. And then I'm in this sarcophagus and I'm crammed in, like wedged in there, and I could see out the little sides. And I'm wearing this super heavy outfit, gold outfit and that thing. And I'm thinking to myself I came to New York to play jazz, what the fuck am I doing. But then I'm looking out and I see my, you know Rubin and Howard Johnson and Cranshaw and the guys, Malone. And I'm thinking I look ridiculous but they really look ridiculous. And then the door opens and I play the solo and it was a live solo, everything was pre-recorded. And then the chick jams me back in, which is not the way we rehearsed it. And suddenly I'm wedging myself back into the sarcoph — that was a bizarre day man. But that's a classic thing.

MR: Boy, I guess so, with a capital C. Okay last question. Did your son, when did your son learn what a gig was?

LM: Oh well he was around musicians right from the get-go so yeah, he knew what I gig was. I remember though when he was about, he must have been eleven or so, the first Blues Brothers tour, the first gig was at Pine Knob and there were like 20,000 people there. And when Belushi introduced me he was on stage by the speakers and they all started going "Blue Lou! Blue Lou!" and he thought they were booing me. And I remember looking over at him and he had this stricken look on his face, and then realized that no, that was actually, and that continues to this day. I get introduced with James and the "Blue Lous" they're booming them.

MR: Awesome. This has been a most marvelous conversation.

LM: Well thank you, brother.

MR: Thank you very much. I wish you the best of luck on your continued tour and whatever multiple projects that you have in your future.

LM: Thank you, man. Thanks, Monk.

MR: All right.

LM: Straight ahead.